

The Shocking FAILURE 2 RESCUE

■ Despite having a warning of over a fortnight, no massive effort was mounted to move men, material and boats for rescue.

■ Though the Kosi breached its embankments on August 18, no state-wide alert was sounded or people warned to evacuate on that day.

■ Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, who also heads the State Disaster Management Authority, was informed of the breach only the next day.

■ On August 20, two days after the breach, the chief minister appealed to the people to evacuate. But, by then it was too late.

**People
evacuated
so far**

7 lakh

**People still
marooned**

8 lakh



wife and five children may be alive, though he remembers with tears that he saw them being pulled away by the floods. He swam for two days before a private boat brought him to the Saharsa camp. He doesn't have any faith in the Government's ability to bring relief.

All across Bihar's affected districts, there is clear evidence that the state administration has collapsed and is unable to cope with the magnitude of the challenge it is facing. The army was finally called in after 10 days of Kosi breaching its embankments in Nepal and flooding vast swathes of Bihar. By then it was too late. Today the shortfall is enormous: There are only 257 relief camps set up, yet the demand is for 2,500—10 times. Though two lakh food packets, which have small portions of rice, lentils and jaggery, are being air-dropped or distributed by hand,

the demand is for two million. Some 5,000 boats are needed for rescue, but only 1,400 are available. That has seen over 13 lakh people like Sinha marooned. "This is the worst-ever tragedy, worse than the Tsunami or Katrina and now only a global effort can help restore normalcy," says former chief minister Jagannath Mishra.

Bihar's misery could have been far less but for a series of shocking failures. The Kosi river is among the most volatile in the region. It has shifted course by over 110 km in the past 100 years. In doing so, it has caused endless devastation, earning for itself the sobriquet "Sorrow of Bihar". This time when heavy rains were reported in the region, in the first week of August the river had begun lashing the embankments at the Kusaha barrage at the Indo-Nepal border menacingly. The Kosi